



PEOPLE & CULTURE • REJECTION DECISION

We're reflecting on your Hackathon 2026 application

Hackathon 2026

Dear Moaz,

Thank you for engaging with us so openly during our conversation. Your genuine enthusiasm for this work came through clearly, and we appreciated your willingness to think through the problem with us.

We've decided not to move forward with your application at this time. We want to be direct about that because you deserve clarity. But we also want to share what we actually observed about you, because we think it matters.

What we saw in you

Our conversation showed us something real: you genuinely understand what this role is about. You grasped the problem we presented. You showed real enthusiasm about the work-that's not something every candidate brings. And beyond the thinking, you demonstrated technical ability. That combination-understanding the problem AND having the capacity to execute on it-is genuinely valuable.

The feedback from our conversation was consistent: you showed genuine enthusiasm and reasonable technical ability. That's meaningful. It suggests you have the foundation to do real work in this space.

Where we're at

The decision to pass wasn't about your capability or your interest. It was about fit for this particular moment and this particular cohort. We had a difficult set of choices to make across our Hackathon positions, and ultimately we moved in a different direction.

What matters going forward

You have genuine enthusiasm for this kind of work, and you have technical ability. Those two things together are the foundation of growth. Keep building on that. Take on projects that let you deepen your technical skills. Stay curious about problems that genuinely interest you. That combination of enthusiasm and capability is what will take you far.

We believe in your potential. Keep going.



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Dear Alishba,

Thank you for taking the time to engage with us and share your thinking. We appreciated your openness and your willingness to work through the problems we discussed.

We've decided not to move forward with your application at this time. We want to be clear about that upfront. But we also want to share what we observed, because we think it's genuinely valuable for your growth.

What stood out about you

Our conversation showed us something important: you have a real attitude toward learning and improving your craft. That's not small. You demonstrated the ability to think about a problem and try to work toward a solution. As an AI student, you're building skills in a space that's rapidly changing, and that kind of learning mindset is what matters most in this field.

What's genuinely encouraging about that is that this mindset is the foundation for becoming a strong engineer. The willingness to engage with hard problems, to think through them, to try solutions—that's how people develop real capability.

Where things stand

The decision to pass wasn't about your learning ability or your potential. You have real potential, and we genuinely believe that. The decision was about fit for this particular role and this particular moment in our hiring.

What we'd encourage

Keep that attitude toward learning. Keep engaging with challenging problems. Build projects that push you to understand things more deeply. Your willingness to learn and improve is valuable—it's the thing that separates people who understand concepts from people who can actually build things.

You're early in your AI journey. Stay curious. Keep building. That's where your growth will come from.

We believe in what you're building toward.



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Hackathon 2026

Dear Maryam,

Thank you for engaging with us and sharing your thinking. We appreciate your time and effort.

We've decided not to move forward with your application. We want to be direct because you deserve that clarity. And then we'd like to share what we observed, because we think it's important feedback as you continue developing your skills.

What we noticed

In our conversation, we saw that you understood some parts of the problem we presented. But what we were looking for was evidence of creative thinking and original contribution—your own ideas, your own problem-solving, your own understanding of the concepts we discussed.

What we observed instead was a project that relied heavily on tools without a clear understanding of the underlying concepts. That gap between using a tool and understanding how it works is really important in technical work. Tools change, frameworks evolve, languages shift. But if you understand the concepts underneath—if you can explain why something works, not just how to use it—that's what stays with you.

What this means

This feedback isn't meant to discourage you. It's meant to clarify something important about what we're looking for in technical roles: the difference between following steps and understanding principles.

What we'd suggest

As you continue your work, we'd encourage you to spend more time understanding the "why" behind the tools you're using. When you use an AI tool, ask yourself: What is it actually doing? Why does it give this output? If I needed to explain this to someone else, could I? That kind of deeper understanding is what builds real capability.

You have the discipline to complete projects. Now invest time in understanding them deeply.

Keep going, but focus on depth of understanding.